

To what extent are the needs of the elderly taken care of in your society?

Key Terms

Needs of the elderly: conditions necessary for a quality life. Can include various types of needs: financial, medical, social-emotional, and material needs of the elderly.

Taken care of: implies that the effort put in by society and the government aimed at fulfilling the needs of the elderly are sufficient, adequate, and effective to provide a satisfying quality of living for the elderly.

Possible Stands:

1. The needs of the elderly are considerably well taken care of as the government and society have stepped up efforts to address these needs, and such efforts are effectively meeting the needs of the elderly.
2. The needs of the elderly in Singapore are largely unmet despite the increased attention to address the needs of the elderly. These efforts fall short of providing an adequate quality of living for the elderly.

Approach for Stand 2:

- A. Acknowledge that efforts have been made to address the needs of the elderly and such efforts may appear to meet the needs of the elderly
- B. Show that there are reasons why these efforts fall short of being able to address the needs of the elderly sufficiently.

Key Arguments:

A1. Elderly people need to have sufficient retirement funds to secure an adequate standard of living during their silver years and the government have implemented several measures to enable financial security of the elderly. Such policies and schemes have given viable options to the elderly to plan and secure a regular income and help them cope with their daily living expenses.

- HDB lease-buyback option enables senior citizens to monetize a portion of their lease, while remaining in their homes.
- CPF Minimum Sum and withdrawal limits have been raised to ensure enough funds for the Retirement Account. CPF Life Plan, converts a lump sum of the CPF money to a monthly income to support a basic standard of living during retirement for about 20 years.
- Under the Silver Support Scheme rolled out in 2016, it would provide eligible elderly Singaporeans with a cash amount of between S\$300 and S\$750 every three months, based on residence and lifetime wages. This is a form of supplement income for the

bottom 20 to 30 per cent of the elderly, who have fewer means in their retirement years. There is automatic qualification with no application required.

B1. However, even with these mandatory savings schemes, the financial needs of the elderly remain largely unmet as high inflation rates, rising cost of living, and longer life expectancy work against these retirement savings and many retirees found themselves in a situation where they do not have sufficient money for old age.

- It is estimated that Singaporeans need at least 1 million dollars to maintain a comfortable standard of living after retirement. According to the HSBC Future of Retirement report, future retirees in Singapore expect their savings to last just 13 out of an average of 23 years in retirement. Some 33 per cent of Singaporeans expect their standard of living to fall when they retire, far above the global average of 23 per cent. (ST 20 Jan 2015:)
- Not everyone is able to earn and save enough for their retirement years. The financial woes among the elderly in the low-income groups are especially visible and we see many of them working as food court cleaners, servers, security guards, tissue-sellers, scrap collectors or scrounging for odd jobs,
- In a 2015 paper on elderly poverty in Singapore written for the Tsao Foundation, Assistant Professor Ng Kok Hoe of the Lee Kuan Yew School of Public Policy noted that the poverty rate among elderly persons in the workforce appeared to have actually increased dramatically. The poverty rate among the working elderly jumped from 13 per cent in 1995, to 28 per cent in 2005 - to 41 per cent in 2011.
- In addition, many elderly people find it difficult to access financial support due to the lack of literacy, and the lack of awareness of governmental policies. It is an uphill task to educate the elderly on financial planning and available support schemes. Language barrier, the lack of technological know-hows to access information, and general apathy invalidate the amount of help given. In the end, those who need it are not able to use it.

A2. It is true that Singapore is lauded internationally for its quality and accessible public healthcare system. And in recent years, the government has taken commendable steps to improve geriatric healthcare, rehabilitation support, and palliative care to meet the needs of the elderly. As an increasing number of senior citizens enter their silver years, various social support schemes were also implemented to help finance healthcare.

- Improved training of healthcare personnel, the construction of new hospitals and community hospitals
- Pioneer Generation Package (PGP) provide special subsidies for MediShield Life premiums, annual Medisave top-ups (up to \$800 a year for life) and an additional 50% off subsidised services and medication at polyclinics and Specialist Outpatient Clinics (SOC) in public hospitals.

- The Seniors' Mobility and Enabling Fund, which provides subsidies for assistive devices and consumables for seniors received a \$100 million top-up.
- \$150 million will be spent over the next five years on transport to subsidised eldercare and dialysis centres.
- There will be a \$300 million top-up to the Community Silver Trust, which provides dollar-to-dollar matching for donations to eligible voluntary welfare organisations providing long-term care services. The fund will be expanded to match donations raised for active ageing programmes as well.

B2: However, while Singapore healthcare system is able to provide quality and accessible healthcare services, the astonishing high healthcare charges and fees have left many Singaporeans worried and apprehensive about their current and future medical needs. Many low and middle-income elderly are unable to afford such high medical costs. In addition, policy loopholes have inadvertently curbed medical subsidies and insurance payouts and high medical costs are not covered adequately.

- An elderly Singaporean who expected that MediShield Life would cover 90 per cent of his post-subsidy bill for a cataract surgery was left shocked when the national health insurance scheme only paid out \$4.50 of the \$4477 cash bill. Singaporeans heavily criticized the incident and were upset that while the whole idea of the insurance scheme is to meet heavy bills, the withdrawal limit and deductible implemented defeat the purpose of insurance.
- In Singapore, the old adage “it is better to die than to fall sick” resonates with many Singaporeans, especially those from the lower and middle income families. 72 per cent of Singaporeans believe “we cannot afford to get sick these days due to high medical costs”, according to a 2012 Mindshare survey. (Today, 22 Feb 2013)
- Nursing home fees in Singapore range from \$1,200 to \$3,500 a month. Eight in 10 of all nursing home patients have a per capita monthly household income of \$700 and below. They receive the maximum subsidy of 75 per cent, which brings their share to \$450 to \$500 a month. Many poor families cannot afford that amount.
- Even former Health Minister Khaw Boon Wan suggested that elderly Singaporeans who fall sick could choose to live in nursing homes in Johor Baru where costs are lower.

A3: Besides financial and healthcare needs, the elderly also need to be connected with their loved ones and lead an active social life. Efforts to alleviate isolation, loneliness and depression among the elderly are increased by providing structural support for the elderly to be connected to the wider community.

- 21 Senior Care Centres and 45 Senior Activity Centres that are being built over the next five years, the elderly can find a nearby centre and join in the activities that are organised.

- Housing policies are implemented to help families live closer together, and this includes the Proximity Housing Grant which provide subsidies to encourage young couples live near their parents. Applications for three-generation flats or through the Multi-generation Priority Scheme doubled from five per cent in 2013 to 10 per cent last year.
- The Government will be widening the reach of the Community Networks for Seniors (CNS) nationwide by 2020. The CNS acts as a one-stop centre by consolidating the services of VWOs, People's Association's (PA) grassroots organisations, regional health systems, and government agencies under one roof. It seeks to provide befriending services for seniors living alone, encourage elderly to join group exercises in the neighbourhood, and help to create awareness of government programmes which will benefit seniors.
- The Government will be boosting home care places to 10,000 by 2020, up from the current 8,000. Daycare capacity will also increase from the current 5,000 places to 6,200 places.

B3: However, the sad truth is many who are aged and sick in Singapore are leading isolated, lonely lives and some of them have few or no family members or dependants to turn to for help or are ignorant or reluctant to ask for help.

- It is very worrying that many elderly people are turning to suicide as the only choice to end their pain and struggles. The number of elderly people taking their own lives reached a record high last year. Some 129 people aged 60 and older committed suicide, despite the total number of suicides declining in the same year.
- The family size is getting smaller and the number of elders living alone or with an elderly spouse is going up. Most adult children also live busy lives and may not be able to give as much attention to their elderly parents as needed or expected. With the ever-rising levels of individualism, apathy and the weakening of the family unit in general, that comes with a fast-paced society, the elderly are often rendered alienated, lonely and ignored in Singapore. Hence the emotional needs of the elderly are often not met, leaving them to feel neglected.
- More abuses by children - According to the Ministry of Social and Family Development, there are some 200 cases of elder abuse a year. But that is just the tip of the iceberg as many may go unreported. The types of abuse vary, from psychological and physical mistreatment, to financial exploitation. Three out of four of abuse victims in Singapore are women.

A4: While some need the money to survive, others work to stay mentally and physically active. Regardless of reason, we need to provide the options for the elderly to be gainfully employed. The government has introduced various work schemes to encourage re-employment and provide more opportunities for elderly workers who want to continue working as long as they are healthy. This keeps them occupied, and gives them a sense of self-worth. It also helps them to integrate into society and enjoy financial independence.

- WorkPro, for employers to get incentives for recruiting mature workers and back-to-work locals, or placing employees on flexible work arrangements. WorkPro can help mature employees become more job-ready and employable. It is an encouraging way to return to work and stay on the job.
- SkillsFuture – to acquire skills to remain employable
- Retirement and Re-employment Act – offers re-employment opportunities to retirees up to age 65. This will be extended to 67 from July 2017. Since the Retirement and Re-employment Act was implemented in 2012, more people have remained in the workforce beyond the official retirement age of 62, and the re-contract age of 65.
- According to the Ministry of Manpower (MOM), more than 40 per cent of people aged 65 to 69 were still working in 2016, compared with just 24 per cent in 2006. Most retirees who continued working beyond retirement did not have a reduction in wages. In 2014, 98 per cent who continued working beyond the age of 62 did not suffer any basic wage cut, with about 10 per cent earning higher wages.

B4: The numbers seem to look good, however, in reality, older workers are having a hard time in their workplaces. Ageism and unfair practices are often not addressed and such discrimination has resulted in a declining number of elderly employees.

- This discrimination against older workers is due to the difficulty in changing the mindset of employers and society in general because of the stereotype of the older worker as being, among other things, "resistant to change, afraid of technology, and unable to learn new things". Employers also often fear that older workers may generate higher costs, such as increased health insurance. (ST 08 Oct 2014)
- Employers still lack a sense of urgency when it comes to hiring older workers. This is according to the Tripartite Alliance for Fair and Progressive Employment Practices (Tafep), which tackles discrimination among employers. (ST 27 Oct 2015)
- Moreover, when the business outlook is not healthy, older workers are hit hardest as retrenchments increase (more laid off in Singapore: MOM report April 2016).
- Although the Retirement and Re-employment Act has raised retirement age to 65, this is still inadequate to eliminate age discrimination, where employers are usually reluctant to interview anyone above the age of 50. The compulsory rehiring scheme only applies to the elderly who were already employed. For the retrenched or unemployed elderly, it had proved to be exceedingly difficult to get a job.

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